



COACH CURRICULUM GUIDE · SEASON ONE

THE FIGHTER'S MINDSET

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1	1-10	1-10	60 min

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CURRICULUM INTRODUCTION

A MESSAGE FROM OUR FOUNDER

Dear Fight Like a Girl coaches,

I founded Box United because boxing completely transformed my life. The sport helped me see I could do far more physically than I ever imagined. That physical strength carried over into every other area of my life — particularly in how I saw my own potential and what I was capable of.

I believe boxing is one of the most powerful tools we have to change girls' lives. It connects mind and body in a way few activities can. In training, there's no room for a wandering mind — boxing demands total presence and focus. Further, for most girls who grow up without access to contact sports, boxing opens the door to a whole new side of their power.

The challenge is that boxing has long been understood only one way: as a sport about fighting. At Box United, we're redefining that vision — using boxing as a tool for girls to unlock their strongest, most confident selves.

Our mission is simple but bold: to bring excellence in boxing to as many Chicago girls as possible, and to let this sport be the tool that transforms their lives. We're here to help girls see themselves as athletes, leaders, and champions.

None of this is possible without you. You are the ones showing our girls what it looks like to work hard, push past limits, and carry themselves with confidence. I am endlessly grateful for your commitment, your energy, and your belief in our students.

MARY KATE VANECKO

Founder & Executive Director, Box United



CURRICULUM INTRODUCTION

PROGRAM RATIONALE

The Fighter's Mindset curriculum was developed by integrating evidence-based best practices with over 20 years of expertise in both boxing and youth development. The design intentionally combines cognitive, social-emotional, and physical skill-building to support holistic growth for young people.

The curriculum is organized around three core pillars: growth mindset, healthy habits, and confidence, skills that are essential not only for success in the boxing gym, but also in school and life. The sequence of practices reflects this structure:

PRACTICES 1-3**GROWTH MINDSET**

PRACTICES 4-6**HEALTHY HABITS**

PRACTICES 7-9**CONFIDENCE**

The program is structured into two 10-week seasons with one practice each week. The second season builds directly on the first, with each practice serving as a continuation of its counterpart, Practice 1 in Season 2 extends the learning from Practice 1 in Season 1. This structure ensures depth, continuity, and reinforcement of learning over time.

Each practice objective is grounded in Bloom's Taxonomy of cognitive skills, progressing in complexity over time. Participants first build foundational knowledge and skills before advancing toward higher-order application, analysis, and reflection (Anderson & Krathwohl, 2001). By the end of the program, youth are not only learning new skills but actively applying them in meaningful ways.

In addition, every practice is anchored in one or two of six positive youth development experiences: challenge growth, engage authentically, expand interests, manage goals, share power, and promote peer bonds. These are consistent with the developmental relationships framework, which highlights the importance of agency, supportive relationships, and opportunities for meaningful challenge (Lerner et al., 2015; Search Institute, 2017).

Together, these experiences create a healing-centered program model that promotes resilience, connection, and confidence. Unlike traditional trauma-informed approaches that focus primarily on harm, healing-centered engagement emphasizes strengths, culture, and collective well-being (Bath, 2008; Ginwright, 2018). This approach is especially relevant in sports-based youth development, where structured physical challenge can serve as a powerful tool for growth (Holt et al., 2017).

SECTION 1

HOW TO READ A PRACTICE PLAN

Every practice plan is built the same way. Once you know the anatomy, you can run any practice in the program without reading it twice.

THE HEADER BLOCK

SEASON

The season number. Practices 1–10 are Season 1; practices 11–20 are Season 2.

PRACTICE TITLE

The name of the practice, with a one-line description underneath.

KEY PHRASE

One phrase to repeat throughout practice. It reinforces the focus.

SUMMARY

The whole practice in a paragraph, the activity, if there is one, and the training focus.

WEEK

The week (1–10) this practice should be run during.

FOCUS

The youth development element this practice builds: confidence, growth mindset, or healthy habits.

MATERIALS

Everything you need. The Fighter's Mindset journal is listed on the weeks it is used, it is never optional on those weeks.

OBJECTIVES

What fighters should walk away with by the end of the practice.

THE FIVE BLOCKS OF PRACTICE

COACH MESSAGE	15 MIN	You lead this. It introduces the day's topic and usually includes an activity tied to the practice title. Read-aloud script sits in a shaded block; everything else is an instruction for you and is not read aloud.
INTENTIONS	10 MIN	Every fighter sets an intention for practice and every fighter shares. Intentions are specific, "I want to work on my hook," "I will throw with speed." For the rest of practice, the team holds one another accountable to them.
TRAINING	25 MIN	Each blue heading is a new piece of boxing training. Training moves in order: review, then a new skill, then mitt and glove work. Watch Out boxes hold the coaching cues to look for.
BURNOUT	7 MIN	The burnout is supposed to burn. Punch counts climb across the season so fighters can see their own improvement. High energy, full effort, nobody finishes alone, fighters who finish cheer on the ones still working.
SHOUT-OUTS	3 MIN	Recognition for the work fighters put in. A shout-out names one person, gives a specific reason, and ends with "snap clap." Never shout out the whole group, the point is that the feedback is personal.

MARKERS YOU WILL SEE ON THE PAGE

SAY	Read this aloud, word for word.	JRNL	Also appears in the fighter journals. Fighters may read it aloud, your call.
☐	Tick the box as you finish each block of practice.	WATCH	Watch Out, the form errors and safety cues to correct on the spot.

SECTION 2

PRACTICE AT A GLANCE

One page for the wall of the gym. Every practice in the program runs this shape.

BLOCK	TIME	NON-NEGOTIABLE
COACH MESSAGE	15	Name the topic. Read the script. Run the activity.
INTENTIONS	5	Everyone shares. End each one with snap clap.
TRAINING	30	Review, new skill, mitt and glove work. Individual feedback to every fighter.
BURNOUT	7	Full punches, counted honestly. Nobody finishes alone.
SHOUT-OUTS	3	One person, one specific reason, snap clap.

THE SHOUT-OUT FORMULA

"I want to give a shout-out to _____ because _____. Snap clap."

If you don't know her name, ask. The group echoes the snap and clap.

COACH REMINDERS

- Repeat the key phrase all practice long.
- Correct form on the spot, not after.
- Name effort out loud when you see it.
- Hold the team to the intentions they set.

ONE PRACTICE, THREE SESSION FORMATS

TWO * 60

SPLIT THE PRACTICE

- Session A: coach message, activity, intentions, and boxing intro.
- Session B: journal, training, burnout, and shout-outs.
- Journal and assessment stay in the session they are printed in.

ONE * 90

AS WRITTEN, UNHURRIED

- Run every block in order at the printed times.
- Spend the extra 30 minutes on mitt work and individual feedback.

ONE * 60

AS WRITTEN, TIGHT

- Coach message 15, intentions 5, training 30, burnout 7, shout-outs 3.
- Cut the review drill first, never the burnout or shout-outs.
- Limited journal use in this format, keep prompts short or send them home.

Practice 01 runs long on coach message, short on training.

SECTION 3

ASSESSMENTS

Assessments are how fighters see their own progress, not a test they can fail.

On selected weeks, fighters complete an assessment during practice. When a practice includes one it says so, build the extra time in and shorten training, never the burnout.

ASSESSMENT WEEKS

WEEK	WHAT HAPPENS	ADD TO PRACTICE
SEASON 1		
Week 1	Jump rope endurance benchmark, one song, unbroken. Pre-survey earlier in the practice.	In the burnout
Week 2	100-punch speed test, 100 clean punches (50 1 · 2 combinations) inside one song.	In the burnout
Week 6	100-punch speed test, midpoint, same song, same format as Week 2.	In the burnout
Week 10	Jump rope endurance and the 100-punch speed test, both repeated. Post-survey closes the day.	In the burnout
SEASON 2		
Week 1	Jump rope endurance baseline, and the Fighter's Mindset journal during intro and expectations.	In the burnout
Week 2	100-punch speed test, baseline for the season.	In the burnout
Week 6	100-punch speed test, midpoint.	In the burnout
Week 10	Jump rope and punch count repeated, final skill levels confirmed, post-survey after the Show Off.	In the burnout

HOW TO FRAME IT FOR FIGHTERS

"Today we're taking measurements so you can see how far you've come. You are competing with your week-one self."

Never rank fighters against each other, never read scores out loud, and always show each fighter her own progress.

Every practice that carries an assessment has a matching log directly after it.

SECTION 4

JOURNALS

Every fighter has a Fighter's Mindset journal for the season, in a middle school and a high school edition. Season 2 has its own journal.

The pre-season and end-of-season surveys are printed in the journal, Weeks 1 and 10 point fighters to a page instead of handing out packets. Set journal activities fall on five weeks of each season. On those weeks the journal is part of the practice, it is listed in Materials and the prompt is printed on the page, marked **JRNL**. It is not optional on those weeks.

JOURNAL WEEKS

SEASON 1

3 · 4 · 6 · 8 · 9

Goal setting, preparation, sleep, giving feedback, and building a combination.

SEASON 2

1 · 2 · 5 · 7 · 10

Set separately, the Season 2 plans carry their own prompts.

TWO VERSIONS

There is a middle school journal and a high school journal. The weeks are the same; the prompts are written for different ages.

This guide prints the middle school prompt. If your fighters are in high school, run the prompt in their journal instead, the page will tell you.

WEEKS WITH NO SET ACTIVITY

On the other five weeks there is no journal activity and no journal in Materials. Writing is not required.

The journal has blank pages at the back for intentions, notes, combinations, and anything else a fighter wants to keep. Point her to them if she wants to write, but on those weeks intentions are spoken to the team, not written.

Journals stay in the gym between sessions unless your site has agreed otherwise. Fighters take them home at the end of Season 2.

SECTION 4

PRACTICE CHECKLIST

Run this before, during, and after every session. It is the same standard at every Box United site.

PREPARATION

- ☐ Staff arrive with enough time to fully prepare the space before fighters arrive, at least 15 minutes before program starts.
- ☐ Gloves and mitts laid out in an easy-to-access space.
- ☐ Tech set up, videos tested and ready.
- ☐ Training equipment (ladders, resistance bands) and SEL materials (journals, enough writing utensils for each person) set out and ready to use.
- ☐ Start on time.

ENTRY

- ☐ Every fighter is greeted by name with a fist bump.
- ☐ Fighters are encouraged to greet each other and introduce themselves to new fighters.
- ☐ Entry expectations are set and reinforced: where to put belongings, wrapping hands, when and how to leave the space to use the restroom.
- ☐ Fighters are given immediate instruction after greeting, a warm-up or team-building activity.

INSTRUCTION

- ☐ Instructions are clear and specific. No fighter appears confused about what she should be doing at any given time.
- ☐ Coach uses a countdown to transition fighters, “voices off and eyes on me in 5...4...3...2...1.”
- ☐ All fighters are meeting listening expectations before instructions are given.
- ☐ Positive behavior narration is used to affirm fighters meeting expectations and to draw in fighters who are not. Don’t call out unwanted behaviors, call in wanted behaviors.

COACHING

- ☐ Coach provides one to three short cues for each boxing technique so fighters can assess themselves and give feedback to partners.
- ☐ Coach walks around the room during group drills to give as much individual feedback as possible.
- ☐ Each fighter gets at least one piece of individual feedback each session.
- ☐ Fighters change partners during the boxing lesson and engage with different fighters.
- ☐ Fighters give feedback to each other. Coach reminds fighters to give feedback during partner work.

CLOSING

- ☐ Shout-out expectations are given.
- ☐ Fighters use each other’s names to give specific shout-outs.
- ☐ Staff make sure all fighters have a safe way home.
- ☐ Program space and equipment is reset for the next session.

PROGRAM CHECKLIST PURPOSE

To ensure a standard of excellence across all Box United program sites, so that every fighter experiences:

SAFETY AND SECURITY IN OUR SPACE

CONFIDENCE IN THEIR BOXING PROGRESS

EFFECTIVE AND ENGAGING INSTRUCTION

PEER CONNECTION AND COMMUNITY

GUIDING PRINCIPLES

VALUE

The level of preparation we invest in our program space reflects the value we have for our fighters. We want the best out of our fighters, so we provide the best environment for them to grow in. A space thoughtfully prepared for them says we care about their experience and believe they deserve our best.

SAFETY

Young people thrive with structure and clear expectations. Consistent routines, rules, and boundaries build safety, security, and control. When fighters understand what to expect and what is expected of them, their confidence and capability increase. Disruptive behavior often comes from trying to take control of a situation that does not feel secure.

CONFIDENCE

Individual feedback from coaches significantly enhances confidence. Run drills that let fighters practice independently, then circulate and give feedback on form and intensity. Start with the positive: “Good rotation on your back foot. For more power in your cross, try lowering your back knee slightly as you rotate... That’s it, you’ve got it.”

RESPECT

Give fighters enough time to finish conversations before transitions, a countdown respects their voice and lets them meet listening expectations. And start on time even when some fighters are late, out of respect for those who arrived on time. If you wait for the full group, have a meaningful activity ready for the fighters already there.

POSITIVE YOUTH DEVELOPMENT

Instead of calling out unwanted behaviors, call in wanted behaviors through positive behavior narration: “Layla is putting on her gloves and standing in boxing stance. Simona is hurrying to get her mitts on before the next round.” It is neither praise nor criticism, and it motivates the fighters who are not yet engaged.

COMMUNITY

We prioritize peer-to-peer connection. Many fighters join to meet new people and build relationship skills, so structure lessons to switch partners and connect with new teammates. Encourage fighters to introduce themselves and welcome new fighters, and train them to give each other feedback, so they own each other’s success.

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